

Signs and Bouncers

I spent six months building an operations system that enhances decision making. The single most useful thing I learned had nothing to do with the tools. It is the difference between a rule and a check, and why one of them survives a bad day.

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01 Signs

Every professional has a rule they have broken more than once.

- It is written down, it is correct, and it still gets broken.
- Almost never by someone who forgot it existed.
- It gets broken by someone who knew it, believed it, and was busy.

A rule is a sign on a door. It works by being read, and it is read by whoever has attention left to spare. **The moment you most need the sign is the moment you have the least attention to give it**, because that moment is busy, or late, or going badly.

So the usual response to a broken rule is to make the sign louder. Bold it. Add a warning. Put up three more. **A louder sign is still a sign.**

02 Bouncers

A bouncer is the same rule standing in the doorway.

- A sign asks you to remember. A bouncer happens whether you remember or not.
- A sign is advice. A bouncer is a step you cannot walk past.
- A sign scales badly under pressure. A bouncer does not care how your day is going.

The difference is not strictness, it is who carries the load. A sign puts the whole job on your attention. **A bouncer moves it into the process, where attention is not required.**

03 Placement

Where the bouncer stands decides whether it is a control or a receipt.

- One at the entrance stops the wrong thing from happening.
- One checking identification on the way out has only told you what already happened.
- Both feel like diligence. Only one changes an outcome.

Most quality processes sit at the exit. Review, audit, retrospective, post mortem. They are worth having and they are not the same thing. **A check that runs after the action can only describe it.**

The practical test is one question. **If this fires and I ignore it, does the thing still happen?** If the answer is yes, I have a sign.

04 The build

The build is smaller than it sounds.

- Take one rule you have broken twice. Twice is the signal, once is chance.
- Write the sentence it forces you to say out loud, before the action, every time.
- Attach it to the moment, not to your memory. A first step, a template field, a required line.
- Let it be annoying. A bouncer that is never inconvenient is not checking anything.

One more thing, and it is the part people skip. **Write down the failure that made you build it.** A bouncer with no story behind it gets removed by the next person who finds it slow, including you.

Six gates in thirteen days

Each one written the day after something broke. Not one written in advance.

JUL 25

COST

a scheduled job ate a month of build minutes

JUL 30

DELETION

a capability died with the files it needed

JUL 30

IDENTIFIER

an address typed from memory, one letter out

AUG 4

SEARCH

six false negatives in five days

AUG 6

ORGANIZATION

a second home for something that had one

AUG 6

FIGURE

a right number quoted at the wrong scope

Mine, with the date each one was written and the failure that caused it.

THE TAKEAWAY

Discipline is not a character trait you top up. It is a placement decision. Move the check from after to before, and from your memory into the process.

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: Written from my own working log, February to August 2026. Every example behind it is a failure I recorded at the time, not one recalled afterwards; The distinction between a control and a detection is standard in safety engineering and in operational risk. The framing here is mine.

General working practice. Not professional, financial or legal advice.